

Creating a Powerful Homepage

**C**

The homepage is the most visited page on any Web site, and its design deserves serious attention so that it can accommodate the rich diversity of customers and their needs. This pattern group describes how to design a powerful homepage to fit the needs of your customers.

C1

HOMEPAGE PORTAL

C2

UP-FRONT VALUE PROPOSITION

C1 HOMEPAGE PORTAL



Figure C1.1

MSNBC gives readers a broad selection of topics to explore, while highlighting news of general interest. With its clearly distinguished links, customers need only a quick glance to see how to navigate the site. Subsections highlighted in the navigation bar show more detailed areas of interest. Readers can customize the news by entering a zip code to get local news.

* BACKGROUND

Used by almost every site and site genre [see Pattern Group A (Site Genres)], a homepage must satisfy the needs of all potential and current customers by establishing the company's identity while providing MULTIPLE WAYS TO NAVIGATE (B1). This pattern forms the core for homepage designs.

A

B1

* PROBLEM

The homepage of a Web site is the portal through which most visitors pass. A homepage must seduce visitors while simultaneously balancing many issues, including branding, navigation, content, and the ability to download quickly.

The homepage is usually the first thing that customers see on your site. This page is critical because, not only is it seen ten to over a thousand times more than any other page, but also it must provide an exceptional customer experience to seduce visitors to continue.

- I2 The space on the page, however, especially ABOVE THE FOLD (I2), is limited. It must be divided among the following goals: creating the right look and feel, building SITE BRAND (E1) and identity, providing valuable content, making navigation easy to use, establishing a cohesive and logical page layout, and delivering high performance. Creating a seductive page while striking a balance among all of these elements requires iterating and refining your page through testing. It also requires that you focus on building trust and providing value and options to your customer population.

Build Site Identity and Brand • Customers need to know that your site holds a valuable promise. They also need to know that it's a promise they can trust you to fulfill. And if the site is valuable, they will want to remember it for later, to use for themselves or to recommend to friends. This is what it means to build a positive identity and a valuable brand. Building a site brand requires presenting a promise of what your site offers, with the goal of attracting customers to come in, and earning their trust and respect by continually fulfilling that promise.

- C2 E1 E4 Attaining this goal means focusing on the company's UP-FRONT VALUE PROPOSITION (C2), SITE BRANDING (E1), and PRIVACY POLICIES (E4) using text, logos, photos, and illustrations to convey that you are trustworthy and professional. But the site itself must reinforce the brand by fulfilling the promise and building trust on every page.

Make a Positive First Impression with the Right Look and Feel • Visitors can be turned off by style alone, or by a homepage look and feel that says, "This site is not for me." Whether a site uses inappropriate colors and graphics, or the writing is unfamiliar or grating, customers respond negatively to a style that is not targeted to them. Neon green, screaming graphics and a skateboarding illustration might appeal to teens, but if you use a similar approach to represent a serious family issue or a

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conservative business, visitors will immediately question if they've come to the right place.

When you design for your target customers, you will get a positive response to your look and feel. Tune the site's style by showing it repeatedly to a dozen or more members of your intended audience. Conduct further testing to determine how *useful* your customers perceive it to be, as well as how *usable* it is. Although it takes time to conduct tests, avoiding early feedback will cost more in the long run when you have to redesign the site because it's not working.

Seduce with Content • Each customer makes a judgment within just a few seconds of entering a site. This is the amount of time you have to get the visitor's attention and keep it. Lively writing and visuals are essential, as is bringing compelling and timely content to the front page. This content can be news, enticing imagery, seductive navigation text, and/or personalization.

Organize content into headlines, summaries, and body. Entice visitors with a catchy HEADLINE AND BLURB (D3) or a CLEAR FIRST READ (I3), and follow through on the target page with the content body text. To make your design cost-effective, establishing a publishing system can help you update and rotate CONTENT MODULES (D2) automatically. Several commercial and open-source tools make this easier to do for larger Web sites.

Personalize Content If Possible • Visitors appreciate coming to a site tailored to their needs because it makes the site feel more useful, faster, and more personal. As a result, customers feel more important. However, a personalized site requires additional effort for visitors to use. This is especially true if customers are required to enter personalization information to use the site at all. Personalized sites, also known as *customized sites*, are also more difficult to design and develop, and they require more Web server and database resources, not to mention support for logins or cookies. But if the content is varied enough, personalization can help customers find what interests them and use the site more effectively.

A personalized homepage will contain CONTENT MODULES (D2) and use PERSONALIZED CONTENT (D4) to tailor the homepage to individual customers (see Figures C1.2 and C1.3). To be willing to provide this personal information, visitors need to trust you enough to tell you, directly or indirectly, about their desires and requests. You must use the information they provide ethically, for their benefit only, and they must trust that you will do so. To help gain their trust, be sure to follow the FAIR INFORMATION PRACTICES (E3) and to have a clear PRIVACY POLICY (E4) in place.

Figure C1.2

My Yahoo! shows how to build customer loyalty by personalizing everything from news and stock quotes to calendars.

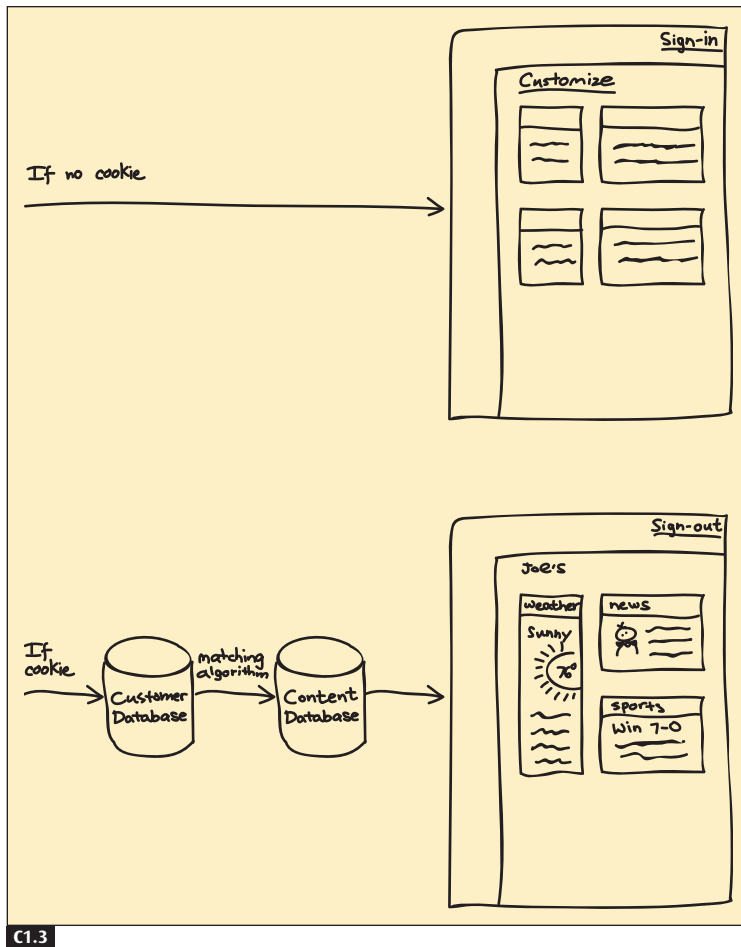


C1.2

(my.yahoo.com, November 14, 2001)

Balance Space for Brand against Space for Navigation • There is a trade-off between space used to communicate the site's value and differentiation, and space used to give customers navigation tools to find what they seek. We have made three observations that provide solutions:

- E1** 1. Because the first read on the homepage is often the SITE BRANDING (E1) in the top left corner, and the second read is the UP-FRONT VALUE PROPOSITION (C2), both parts must be instantly clear to customers. If they aren't, customers may become doubtful, confused, or irritated enough to go elsewhere. Have your team focus on designing these two parts well, rather than on using more space on the homepage for branding.

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C1.3
Figure C1.3

Personalized homepages are customized for each customer. This sketch shows how to return a default page for a new customer (top), and a personalized page for a returning customer (bottom).

- Customers skim when they read on the Web, and they will skim your homepage as well, looking for succinct phrases and links they recognize and deem potentially valuable. Focus your design on finding the proper wording for these phrases, and on making them easy to skim. Be sure to use DESCRIPTIVE, LONGER LINK NAMES (K9).
- Every primary audience is really composed of many subgroups, and each subgroup needs answers to its specific questions. For example, if the primary audience consists of investors, you must answer the questions of both institutional investors and direct investors. Dedicate 95 percent of the area and links above the fold to the primary audience. Keep the remaining area and links for secondary groups.

K9

3

If the primary audience is a products and services buyer, answer the questions of the decision maker, recommender, and technical reviewer. You can often take these customers to a subsidiary page where they can select their role to obtain more targeted information. Use the techniques described in Chapter 3 (Knowing Your Customers: Principles and Practices) to understand these roles for your customers and your site.

B1

Make Navigation Easy to Use • The only way people can find their way around a site is by understanding the navigation. This means that all levels of visitors—with varying degrees of computer skills, domain expertise, and experience with your Web site—must quickly comprehend how to get around. Give your customers MULTIPLE WAYS TO NAVIGATE (B1) so that each customer has a way that fits his or her previous Web experience.

There are two essential rules to navigation. First, people know that some things on a Web page can be clicked on. *Do not make them guess what's clickable and what's not.* Second, people know that when they click on something, an action will take place. *Make those actions clear and predictable.*

K9

B2

B1

Provide Strong Information Scent • **Information scent** is the perceived proximity to desired information. A good homepage provides multiple cues to improve information scent, such as meaningful text, seductive images, DESCRIPTIVE, LONGER LINK NAMES (K9), BROWSABLE CONTENT (B2), and MULTIPLE WAYS TO NAVIGATE (B1). Strong information scent will help your customers easily understand how the information on your site is organized and bring them closer to the content they seek. See BROWSABLE CONTENT (B2) for more tips on improving information scent.

B2

Provide a Cohesive and Logical Page Layout • A disorganized page layout can confuse site visitors. They need to be able to identify the most important objects to view immediately so that they know they're in the right place.

I1

D1

I3

Create a homepage that makes it easy to understand what the Web site is about and where things are located. Implement a clean GRID LAYOUT (I1) in a PAGE TEMPLATE (D1) that organizes the entire page cohesively. Apply the CLEAR FIRST READS (I3) pattern. The **first read**, a concept from graphic design, is the single element that draws their attention first and pulls the Web page together. Having a clear first read on your homepage helps customers quickly and easily identify the most important information, and it provides a design focus for the page.

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Place the most important navigation tools and content ABOVE THE FOLD (I2), making them visible so that the customer will not have to scroll down. People don't always realize that they can scroll down for more information, and they might miss out on things you want them to see right away, if those things are below the fold.

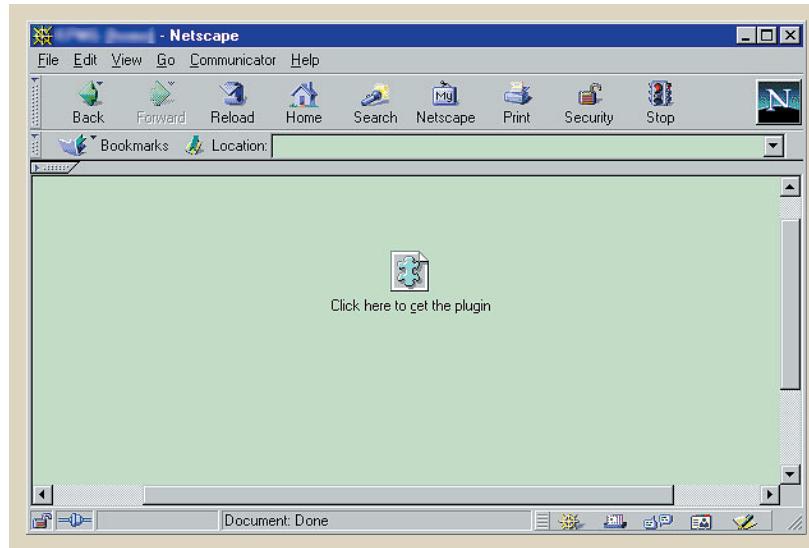
Make the Homepage Download Quickly • You know all about this. If the homepage of a new site that you're visiting takes a very long time to load, you're likely to back out to another site.

Test your site to ensure that the homepage takes no more than a few seconds to download and appear in a browser. Here are some strategies for faster downloads:

- The images on your homepage are guaranteed to be the slowest the first time a visitor comes to your site because at that point the images are not cached yet. To combat this problem, take advantage of HTML POWER (L4) and use text as much as possible instead of graphics. HTML text is the first thing that downloads, so the visitor gets all the necessary text information without waiting for image downloads.
- Some people will tell you that HTML text is ugly. Make the best of it by working with a Web-savvy graphic artist who can move your site to the next design level. This professional can choose the right complementary font colors, background colors, and font styles and make an exciting and dynamic homepage design.
- Use FAST-LOADING IMAGES (L2) to improve the speed of your site. Crop, shrink, reduce colors, and increase compression to make images smaller and faster to download.
- For legacy designs, but not for new sites that can use STYLE SHEETS (D11) exclusively, use SEPARATE TABLES (L3) for page layout instead of one large HTML table. The problem with using a single large table is that it forces customers to wait until all of the images are loaded before they can see anything. If you separate your Web page into multiple tables, people can see some parts of the page as it is loading.
- On the main homepage, avoid slow-loading content such as sounds, splash screens, animations, and Java applets. If you include features such as these, not only will you make your main homepage slower to load, but you will risk having it look like Figure C1.4 to visitors who do not have the latest technologies installed on their computers.

Figure C1.4

Don't let this be your homepage. Unless there is an extremely compelling reason, keep Java applets, browser plug-ins, and other “bleeding-edge” technologies off of your main homepage.

**C1.4**

* SOLUTION

On your homepage portal, establish and reinforce the value of your site with a strong, clearly stated promise that is fulfilled on every page of the site. Dedicate 95 percent of the area and links above the fold to the visitor groups that comprise 95 percent of the total visitor population. Keep the remaining area and links for visitor groups that make up the remaining 5 percent. Use additional links in the footer of the homepage to make explicit links for each group, including those in the 5 percent category. Build a homepage layout that provides strong cues to define navigation and content, and that downloads quickly. Test your homepage design to ensure that you have created the right look and feel—one that seduces visitors with content, regardless of whether it is personalized.

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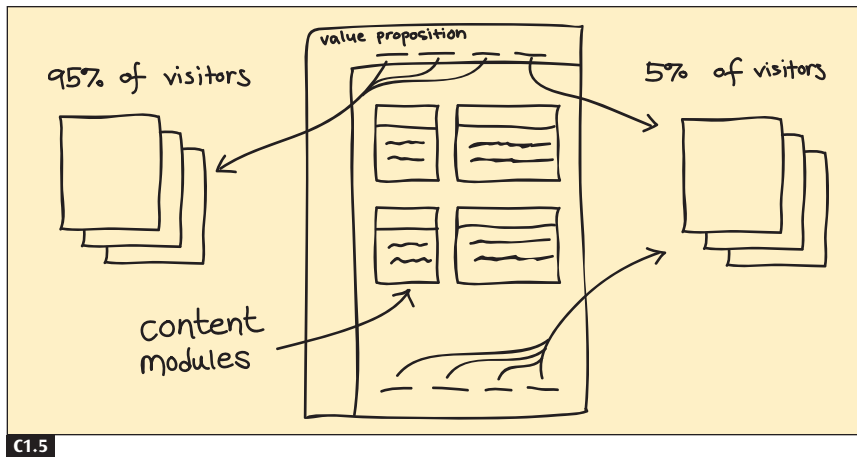


Figure C1.5

Sketch out strong first impressions of your homepage with compelling titles and logos, and simple navigation.

* OTHER PATTERNS TO CONSIDER

On the homepage, clearly state the site's UP-FRONT VALUE PROPOSITION (C2), show the SITE BRANDING (E1), and provide links to the site's PRIVACY POLICY (E4).

Use a publishing system to automatically update and rotate CONTENT MODULES (D2) on the homepage. A personalized homepage will contain CONTENT MODULES (D2) and use PERSONALIZED CONTENT (D4) to tailor the homepage to individuals.

Make navigation easier and provide stronger information scent by creating consistent MULTIPLE WAYS TO NAVIGATE (B1) and by establishing your navigation design on the homepage. Create BROWSABLE CONTENT (B2) and use NAVIGATION BARS (K2), OBVIOUS LINKS (K10), ACTION BUTTONS (K4), DESCRIPTIVE, LONGER LINK NAMES (K9), and EMBEDDED LINKS (K7).

Create an easy-to-read homepage using a PAGE TEMPLATE (D1) and GRID LAYOUT (I1) with CLEAR FIRST READS (I3). Put the most important navigation tools and content ABOVE THE FOLD (I2).

Have a LOW NUMBER OF FILES (L1) on your homepage, and use FAST-LOADING IMAGES (L2) and HTML POWER (L4) to increase both its actual and its perceived performance.

C2
E1
E4

D2
D2 D4

B1
B2
K2 K10 K4
K9 K7
D1
I1 I3
I2
L1
L2 L4

UP-FRONT VALUE PROPOSITION **C2****Figure C2.1**

Epicurious's value proposition—"for people who love to eat"—is reinforced by the images, navigation, and text on its homepage.

**C2.1**

(www.epicurious.com, June 16, 2006)

* BACKGROUND

- C1** The HOMEPAGE PORTAL (C1) must communicate the purpose of the site immediately and clearly. This pattern describes how to come up with that message.

* PROBLEM

On many Web sites, people often cannot tell upon arrival what the company or site offers.

If first-time visitors to your Web site don't see a clear, persuasive promise about what your company or site has to offer, they must figure it out on their own. Sometimes they leave the site right then and there because they cannot be bothered or they don't have time. Sometimes they surf around your site to find the answer, and sometimes they never do understand the site or company's full value, even if you have stated it on the homepage. This miscommunication can lead customers to undervalue your site or, worse, your entire company in their critical first moments of using your site. Changing a customer's initial impression later can cost you substantial money and time because you will have to earn their trust in order to reeducate them.

Even if you get it right, a value proposition alone will not make a site valuable. You must fulfill your promise on every page and reinforce it offline through your business practices. A compelling value proposition, along with these other elements, will create a positive impression with customers. This in turn will build trust and goodwill that you can enhance and expand over time. This pattern focuses on offering you a proven way to articulate a powerful promise.

To get there, you will need to work through many ideas and iterations until you create the strongest statement possible. Our solution provides a framework to make this development easier.

Requirements • The homepage is an advertisement for the rest of the site. It must sell customers on continuing their journey to explore, use, possibly purchase, and return again and again. As David Ogilvy reveals in his book *Ogilvy on Advertising*, an advertisement is much more effective when it persuasively promises a unique benefit. Not only are customers more likely to read it, but they are also more likely to purchase the product. For a Web site, that means visitors are more likely to explore and use your site.

Here's what you need (see Figure C2.2):

- A persuasive promise
- A unique offering
- Descriptive wording and images that are easily and quickly understood

Figure C2.2

These value propositions quickly communicate the types of services that the companies behind them offer. They speak broadly to the overall benefit, instead of one particular benefit, and they are easy to understand and quick to read. Read each and rate for yourself how persuasive and unique they are.



Creating a persuasive and unique statement about what your company provides can be difficult without the right processes, people, and tools. To write and select the best promise, use creativity and brainstorming exercises to pull together an initial list of candidates. Customer research, which has been proven to help identify the most persuasive offer, can also help you shape your promise.

Exercise 1: Articulate the Value

Develop an initial list of value propositions. Invite everyone on the site design team to a brainstorming session, especially the most visionary, imaginative, and vocal members of the team. Seat everyone in a comfortable space that has a whiteboard on the wall. Ask this question: In ten words or less, what do we promise to our visitors that is persuasive and unique?

In a brainstorming session, no one passes judgment. Every statement is equally valuable, and no statement is wrong. Everything goes. Write down all suggestions, even if you don't like them, they're longer than your target number of words, or they're not unique or as persuasive as you would like. Continue for half an hour or more, if time permits. Then copy all the ideas onto a piece of paper or a computer for later review (this is not the final step).

Exercise 2: Select the Strongest Candidates

Distribute the list developed in the brainstorming session to a core group of marketing and business visionaries on the site design team. Ask them to

C2

UP-FRONT VALUE PROPOSITION

identify the ten most persuasively articulated value propositions that make a unique offer. Tell them to be prepared to defend their choices. Convene a meeting to choose the ten best promises. To determine the best, ask these questions: Is this promise consistent with our strategic direction? Is it persuasive? Is it unique? If not, why not? Can it be improved? This meeting could easily take longer than the initial brainstorming session, so limit the time to a couple of hours to make the process manageable.

Research Project 1: Have Customers Nominate the Best

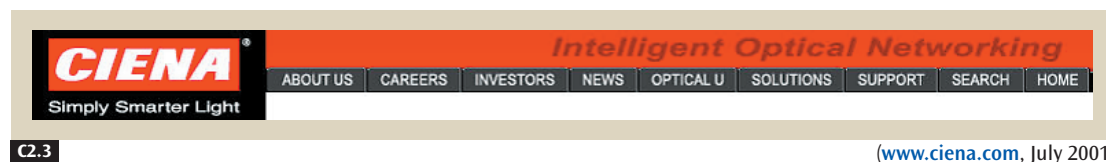
Now turn to your customer base and ask a sample of 100 customers to participate in a research survey to rate each of the team's ten chosen value propositions [for an overview of customer research methods, see Appendix A (Running Usability Evaluations)]. Ask customers to rate the promises for *importance*, from "not important at all" (0) to "very important" (10); and for *uniqueness*, from "not unique at all" (0) to "very unique" (10). From the results, identify the value propositions that averaged a 7 or higher in both importance and uniqueness. If none of the value propositions rates this high, go back to Exercise 1 and start over.

Research Project 2: Have Customers Select the Top Value Proposition

Turn to your customer base one more time (coordinate this test with other research to reduce time and costs) and ask a sample of 100 customers to choose their top choice from the highly rated value propositions found in the previous test, again based on its importance and uniqueness. The winner is the one that most appeals to your customers. Congratulations! You've got your value proposition.

Integrate Your Value Proposition into the Site • Now develop some sample designs that emphasize this new value proposition. Think about the different ways you can get your message across to customers in a quick, simple fashion (see Figure C2.3). Other patterns that will help include SITE BRANDING (E1) and CLEAR FIRST READS (I3).

E1 I3



C2.3

(www.ciena.com, July 2001)

Figure C2.3

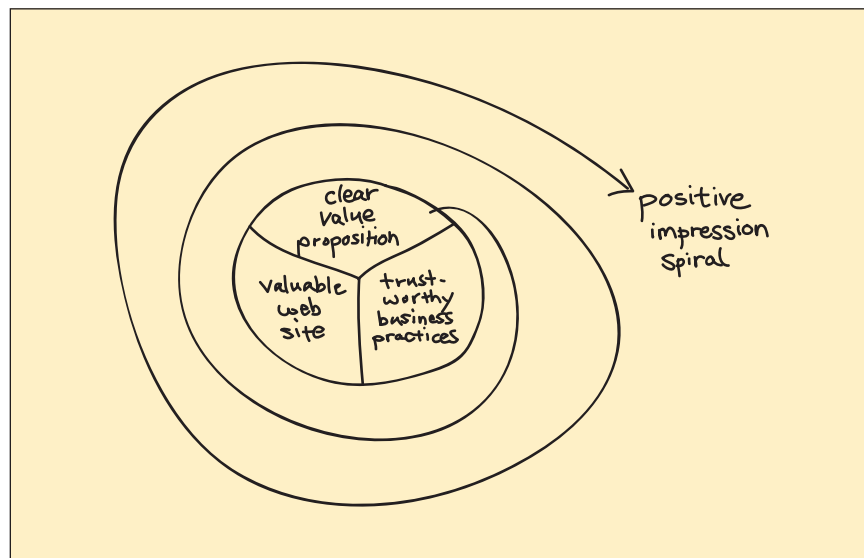
Ciena's value propositions are integrated directly into the main logo and are some of the first things visitors will read.

* SOLUTION

Your value proposition is a site advertisement that must persuasively articulate your company's uniqueness. Use team brainstorming to develop ideas, and refine the best ideas into a list of the top ten candidates. To determine the best value proposition, ask your customers to rate each promise on importance and uniqueness. Place the value proposition next to your logo on the homepage for quick scanning and maximum exposure.

Figure C2.4

A customer's positive impression starts with a clear value proposition in the form of a persuasive and unique promise. By fulfilling the promise through a valuable Web site and trustworthy business practices, you can continue to build customer loyalty and a strong reputation through word of mouth.



C2.4

* OTHER PATTERNS TO CONSIDER

- E1** Integrate your value proposition with your SITE BRANDING (E1), making it a CLEAR FIRST READ (I3).
- I3**

